

A FREE ADVENTURE KEEPER • LONG ISLAND DUNGEON MASTER

WHAT THE ROPE WILL BEAR

The only crossing for forty miles is a rope with eleven hauls left in it.

An encounter for four characters of 3rd level • one location • 45 to 60 minutes • SRD 5.1

An encounter for four characters of 3rd level, scaling to 5th. Se-compatible (SRD 5.1).

THE HOOK

The only crossing for forty miles is a rope with eleven hauls left in it, and the woman at the winch has already decided what those eleven are for.

At a glance: one location · 45 to 60 minutes · one optional fight · no loot.

THE SETUP

The winter road stops at the Skarn. Two hundred feet down, the river runs half under ice and half open and black. Three hundred feet across, a slate quarry called Overcut has thirty people in it and no way home until the low road thaws.

One line crosses: a doubled hemp cable on an oak wheel, with a wicker cage on the end that takes one person or two hundred pounds of anything that does not argue. Ingrith Lorimer has worked that wheel for nineteen winters, and every morning before light she walks the cable as far as her arms reach and puts her hands on it.

It is going. One strand of the three has parted out over the middle where no hands will ever get to it, and the line creaks now in a register it did not have in autumn. Ingrith has done the only arithmetic anybody has done. She counts what is left in hauls, because a haul is the unit that means anything on this ledge. Her number is **eleven**.

Eleven hauls of flour and salt fish is nine days of half rations for thirty people. The low road opens in nine days. Or fourteen. Or whenever it opens. So a haul spent on a body is most of a day of food for everyone up there, and Ingrith will not spend one. There is a woman at Overcut named Elowen Tasker with a leg crushed under a slab, the leg is going bad, and Ingrith has sent up what medicine she has and will not send the cage.

The party needs to be on the far side tonight.

READ ALOUD

The road ends at a rail and a drop. Across the gap the quarry lights are small and orange, and the only sound that carries is somebody up there counting sacks out loud. On this side a rope as thick as your wrist comes out of a great wheel and goes away into the dark over the river, and it moves. Not swinging. Working, the way a thing works when it is holding. A woman in oiled wool sits under a lantern with a slate on her knee. She does not get up. She looks first at how many of you there are and then at what you are carrying, and you can watch her do the sum.

WHAT'S REALLY GOING ON

Nothing is hidden here. That is the whole difficulty.

Ingrith is not guarding a secret and she is not running a swindle. She gives the party the count in the first minute and turns the slate around so they can read the tally. She was handed a failing rope and thirty people and no help, and she did the thing nobody else did. She put a number on it.

The number is where she is thin, and she knows it. Press her, or make the Insight check below, and she says the thing she has never once said across the gap: **eleven is a guess**. A three-strand cable with one strand gone might have eleven

hauls left in it or eighty. Rope does not warn you. It holds and holds and holds, and then it is two ends going in opposite directions, and there is no test she can run from this side that would tell her anything.

So the count is not a lie and it is not a measurement. It is the only number anybody has, and she is running a crossing on it because a crossing cannot be run on *we do not know*.

Play her as a woman doing sums out loud. She is courteous and unhurried, and entirely unmoved by how badly you need this, because everyone who arrives here needs it badly and the rope does not care. Her one argument, made plainly:

READ ALOUD

"Somebody had to put a number on it. I did. Bring me a better one and I will use it."

And she is not wrong. That is the encounter.



MORE TO PAINT

The voice from the other side. Osric Deben runs the quarry face. Every few hours he shouts across through a speaking horn, reading Ingrith the same list. It gets shorter each time.

READ ALOUD

The horn goes off across the gap, flattened by the distance into something almost bored. "Flour to Thursday. Fish to Friday if we go to one meal a day." A pause, and the wind. Then, quieter and not meant to carry: "Ingrith. Tasker's leg is black to the knee." The woman under the lantern writes something on her slate and does not answer.

THE OLD CUT: PREP BEFORE YOU READ THE BOX

your party will ask whether there is another way across. There is, and it is the only reason this encounter has a fight in it. Ingrith tells them where without being asked. Do not volunteer the whistlers.

A quarter mile north the gorge wall carries a stair of quarry notches, cut by the crew that opened Overcut before anybody thought of a rope. It drops to the scree on this side, crosses the river on an ice shelf at the narrows, and goes up the far wall in two long pitches with a ledge between them. Nobody has used it in nine years.

READ ALOUD

"There's the old cut, quarter mile north," she says. "Notches. Good stone. You can be down to the scree and up the other wall by dark tomorrow if you're strong and nobody's stupid." She turns the slate over on her knee. "Four went that way nine winters back. None of the four came off it. I'd not send you and I'd not stop you."



THE INTERESTING CHOICE

The party can be across in ten minutes. There are eleven in the rope and she will spend one, if they ask her for it in words.

That is the trick of this encounter: **she says yes**. There is nothing to break into and nobody to fight for the winch. What she will not do is let anyone pretend it was free. She asks them, once, to say which day of Overcut's bread they are taking. Then she works the wheel.

Three doors, and none of them is clean:

- **Spend a haul.** It works exactly as advertised. Nobody is cursed and nothing is hidden. Thirty people eat a little less because four people were in a hurry, and Ingrith will not shame anyone for it. She writes it down and reads it back.
- **Take the old cut.** Costs her nothing. Costs the party a day and a night on iced notches in the cold, plus whatever is nesting up there. This is the door where the party pays instead of strangers, and a table that picks it should be told plainly that they picked it.
- **Change what the eleven are for.** The rich one, and the only door that puts somebody different on that shelf. Stop hauling food and start hauling people. Eleven hauls is eleven people. There are thirty. She would be picking eleven names and leaving nineteen with no food coming and no crossing left, which is exactly why she has not done it. It is a real reason. It is also how she has managed never to choose a name.



MECHANICS

Read the count (Wisdom / Insight, DC 13). On a success the party sees what Ingrith is standing on top of: she is frightened of that number and she has no better one. Failure costs only the benefit of the doubt, and she reads as a toll-keeper inventing a shortage.

Read the rope (Intelligence / Investigation, DC 15). A character proficient with carpenter's tools or weaver's tools has advantage. On a success, say it plainly: one strand of three is gone, the other two are sound as far as anyone can reach, and no honest person could turn that into a number. Fail-forward: they learn the fray is real and take the eleven as fact, which makes the third door much harder to argue.

Argue the count (skill challenge, three successes before two failures, all DC 15). Charisma (Persuasion) to get her to say out loud that the number is a guess. Intelligence (Investigation) to show her what the fray actually means, available only if somebody made the rope check. Wisdom (Insight) to name the thing under it: she has been rationing a rope so that she never has to decide about Elowen Tasker's leg. At two failures she goes quiet and thanks them for their opinion, and the eleven stands. She will still run the cage for them, which is the cruelty of her.

The old cut. Two pitches on the far wall, an hour each, with the Halfway Bench between them. The Bench sits thirty feet above the scree and is eight feet wide, and the top of the upper pitch is forty feet above the Bench. Each pitch is one **DC 13 Strength (Athletics)** check per character. A failed pitch drops nobody: it costs an hour and a level of exhaustion, and they try again.

The light on the wall (four boxes). Tick one box for each hour the party spends on the cut. When the fourth box fills, the sun comes off the west wall and the notches ice over: every Athletics check on the cut is DC 15 from that point, and the whistlers hunt.

The whistlers (3). Use the SRD *harpy* stat block with no changes, reflavoured: pale cliff-things with a wingspan like a door, living in the wind-scoured hollows above the Bench. Their Luring Song does not sound like singing out here. It sounds like the winch wheel turning, which in this gorge is the sound of somebody finally coming for you. Men have been reaching toward it on this wall for nine years.

Encounter math: three whistlers (CR 1, 200 XP each) = 600 XP, adjusted to **1,200** by the tool (`encounter_xp.py --party 4x3 --cr 1,1,1`), a **Hard** fight for four 3rd-level characters against thresholds of 300 / 600 / 900 / 1,600.

All three are present from round one and nothing arrives later, so that tier is the whole fight rather than the back half of it.

Reaching for the wheel. Luring Song does not make anyone step off the wall. It makes them want to be nearer the sound, and a quarry notch is eleven inches wide. At the start of each of its turns while charmed and on the stair, a creature makes a **DC 10 Dexterity (Acrobatics)** check. On a failure it comes off: from the lower pitch, a thirty-foot fall to the scree for **3d6 bludgeoning damage**, and the slope carries them the rest of the way down prone; from the upper pitch, a forty-foot fall to the Bench for **4d6 bludgeoning damage**, prone on the ledge. A fall is damage from a source other than the harpy, so the save against the song repeats at once. **A character who comes off is out of the fight and has to climb their pitch again.** Nobody dies of this wall unless your table wants them to.

Ingrith Lorimer. SRD *commoner*, with Insight and Persuasion at +5. She will not fight for the winch. If the party takes it by force she steps back and lets them, and writes down what they took.

THE WHISTLERS

Three of them. SRD harpy, reflavoured, stat block unchanged.

AC 11

HP 38 (7d8 + 7)

Speed 20 ft., fly 40 ft.

CR 1 (200 XP)

Luring Song DC 11 Wis

Claws +3, club +3

LURING SONG

DC 11 Wisdom saving throw or charmed while it sings. A charmed creature moves toward the harpy by the most direct route and repeats the save whenever it takes damage from a source other than the harpy.

MULTIATTACK

Claws for 2d4 + 1 slashing and club for 1d4 + 1 bludgeoning, both at +3 to hit.

THE WHOLE FIGHT

Three whistlers = 600 XP raw, **1,200 adjusted**, a **Hard** fight for four 3rd-level characters against thresholds of 300 / 600 / 900 / 1,600. All three are present from round one.



OUTCOMES

- **They spend a haul** → across in ten minutes, recorded in a hand that does not editorialize. The next time they come through Overcut, somebody there knows exactly whose meal that was.
- **They take the old cut** → they arrive a day late and cold, probably one member short of upright, and the count is untouched. Ingrith notes that too, in the same column.
- **They argue her down** → she runs the line out that night for people instead of flour. Eleven come down with Elowen Tasker first, and nineteen watch the cage go. If the low road opens on the ninth day, she spent her crossing on eleven who would have walked out anyway. If it opens on the fourteenth, she saved eleven lives and cost nineteen their food line. She will not know which for a week, and neither will your party.
- **They take the winch by force** → they get across, Ingrith lets them, and the count is still eleven and still hers. A table that tries to win this by force finds out there was nothing to win.

What they leave with: no coin and no gear. If they argue the count down, eleven people and the nineteen they did not take.



SCALING

- **3rd level:** three whistlers as written, a **Hard** fight at 1,200 adjusted XP. The wall is the dangerous part, not the birds.
- **Below 3rd:** skip the cut, or run a single whistler as a warning that turns the party back to the winch. This is a conversation with a fight beside it, and the conversation works at any level.
- **4th level:** four whistlers, 800 XP raw, **1,600 adjusted**, still a **Hard** fight (thresholds 500 / 1,000 / 1,500 / 2,000).
- **5th level:** whistlers stop being a threat and the tool says so plainly. Six against four 5th-level characters is 2,400 adjusted against a Medium threshold of 2,000. To make the wall bite at 5th, lean on the light clock and the cold instead of adding bodies.
- **Larger party:** add whistlers. Never make Ingrith a fight. She is not an obstacle. She is the person who did the arithmetic first.



D10: WHAT THE SKARN DOES WHILE YOU ARE ON THE WALL

Roll once per pitch, or whenever the climb needs a heartbeat. Most of these cost a decision rather than hit points.

ROLL IT OR PICK IT

D10 WHAT THE SKARN DOES

- 1 The notch is ice.** One notch is filled flush with clear ice and looks exactly like stone from below. The first character to weight it makes a DC 10 Dexterity (Acrobatics) check or hangs by the hands, which costs their next turn getting back on.
- 2 The updraft.** Warm air comes off the open water below and goes straight up the wall. It is the first warm thing anybody has felt in two days and it makes a person want to stay exactly where they are.
- 3 Somebody's rope.** A fixed line, nine years old, knotted through a notch by a person who did not come back. It will hold a pack. Nobody will agree on whether it will hold a person, and finding out is a decision rather than a check.
- 4 The horn.** Osric Deben's voice comes off the far shelf, close enough now to make out words. He is not calling to the party. He is reading the list again, and they can hear which day it has got down to.
- 5 One goes past.** A whistler crosses the face forty feet out, unhurried, not looking at anybody, and lands somewhere above. It does not attack. It has seen them, and now they know that it has.
- 6 The ice shelf lets go.** Below them the river takes back a slab of its own cover with a sound like a door slamming in a stone room. Anyone still to make the bottom crossing has colder water to make it in.
- 7 A handhold that is not stone.** Fingers close on something smooth and light and wrong in the dark, and it comes away. It is a finger bone, and it belongs to one of the four who did not come off this wall.
- 8 The sun leaves.** Tick the light clock whether it was due or not. The far wall goes blue, the notches begin to glaze, and every Athletics check on the cut is DC 15 from here.
- 9 A place to stand.** A ledge wide enough for two people to sit down with their backs to the rock. It is the only genuinely good thing on this wall. Give it to them. Tell them what it costs in hours and let them take it anyway.
- 10 The wheel turns.** Everybody on the wall hears the winch working, plain and unmistakable, from a quarter mile south where nobody is standing. It might be the wind in a notch. It might be Ingrith spending a haul she said she would not spend. It is neither, and they will argue about it the rest of the way up.



RUNNING THIS SOMEWHERE ELSE

Two rows of the d10 carry any mechanics at all. Row 1 asks for a DC 10 Dexterity check against a slip, and row 8 raises the climb difficulty to DC 15. Everything else on that table is the gorge behaving like a gorge. The fight wants a flying ambusher with a song that pulls people toward it, which every game has under some name.

The count is not a rule at all. It is one woman on a ledge with a rope, and a number nobody can check.



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WHAT THE ROPE WILL BEAR

One page for the table

THE COUNT

One line across the Skarn. One strand of three has parted. Ingrith Lorimer says **eleven hauls** are left. Eleven hauls is nine days of half rations for the thirty at Overcut, so a haul spent on a body is most of a day of their food. **Eleven is a guess and she knows it.**

THREE DOORS

1. **Spend a haul.** She says yes, and writes down what it cost.
2. **Take the old cut.** Two pitches, DC 13 Athletics each, three whistlers, a four-box light clock.
3. **Change what the eleven are for.** Eleven people down. Nineteen left on the shelf.

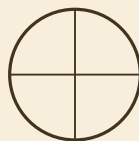
EVERY NUMBER ON ONE LINE

DC	THE CHECK
13	Wisdom (Insight): read the count. She is frightened of it and has no better one.
15	Intelligence (Investigation): read the rope. Nobody can turn that fray into a number.
15	Argue the count. Three successes before two failures.
13	Strength (Athletics): one pitch of the old cut. DC 15 once the light clock fills.
10	Dexterity (Acrobatics): charmed on the stair. Fail and you come off.
11	Wisdom save against Luring Song, from the harpy stat block itself.

Falls. Lower pitch 30 ft, 3d6 bludgeoning, prone on the scree. Upper pitch 40 ft, 4d6 bludgeoning, prone on the Bench. Out of the fight, not out of the game.

The fight. Three whistlers, SRD *harpy* unchanged: AC 11, HP 38, fly 40 ft, Luring Song DC 11. Adjusted 1,200 XP, **Hard** for four 3rd-level characters.

The light on the wall. Four boxes, one per hour on the cut. On the fourth the sun leaves the west wall, every Athletics check becomes DC 15, and the whistlers hunt.



4 SEGMENTS